The silent flower experiment

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Introduction

People spend their day focused on routine, rarely experiencing unexpected kindness. In this experiment, I silently gave a flower to 12 strangers to see how a simple, wordless gesture would affect their reactions and emotions.

How do strangers respond emotionally and behaviorally when offered a flower with no words, context, or explanation?

Theoretical Background

Prosocial Behavior

Acts that benefits others without expecting anything back.

Nonverbal Communication

Facial expressions, gestures, and body language.

Violation of Norms

Humans react strongly to unexpected gestures.

Emotional Contagion

Humans react strongly to unexpected gestures.

Hypothesis

01. Most people will smile when receiving a flower silently, because unexpected kindness triggers immediate positive emotion.

02. People will show confusion or surprise since receiving a gift from a stranger violates normal social expectations.

03. Some individuals will ask questions (like “why?” or your name), because silent gestures increase curiosity and the need for explanation.

Procedure

- Prepared 12 flowers
- Approached 12 strangers silently
- Handed them a flower with a gentle smile
- Did not speak
- Friend filmed reactions discreetly
- After the interaction I explained the project and asked for their consent to use their reaction and include their data in the study.
- Recorded behavioral + emotional responses

Reaction Categories

Reaction Category	Count (out of 12)
Smiled	12
Looked confused	12
Asked “why?”	6
Tried to talk	6
Refused	0
Negative reactions	0

Conclusion & Ethics

- A silent act of kindness creates strong emotional reactions
- Humans respond deeply to nonverbal warmth
- Even one flower can interrupt stress and create connection
- Silence made the gesture more powerful

Ethics

- No harm
- No pressure
- People were free to walk away
- No personal info collected

Thanks!